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The Retreat of the Lion: The Story of Islam in Al-Andalus

For this final paper, I will be focusing on the region of Al-Andalus from 968 CE to 1362 CE with a focus on luxury and royal life. The sources I will be using are the Pyxis of Al-Mughira from Cordoba 968 CE, a Folio from a Qur'an manuscript from the Emirate of Granada in the late 13th century, and the Palace of Lions in the Alhambra in Granada 1362 CE. I will be looking at the influences of these pieces and what the sources tell us about the state of politics and luxury life in Al-Andalus. Specifically, my larger point of analysis will be between the Pyxis of

Al-Mughira and the Court of the Lions, showing how the symbolism of Lions describes the state of Islamic power over Al-Andalus.

The first object of analysis, the Pyxis of Al-Mughira, was created by craftsmen in a workshop in Cordoba as a commissioned piece for the son of Caliph ‘Abd al-Rahman III. We know this because the lid of the Pyxis has Kufic script carved around it that establishes the name of the prince Al-Mughira, the year that the Pyxis was created in, and establishes Al-Mughira’s father as the caliph by referring to him as “Commander of the faithful.” The script, in addition to having the name and date, has a blessing for Al-Mughira, asking Allah to bless

the newly matured Prince. In retrospect, this blessing is quite sad knowing that Prince Al-Mughira was executed.

The Pyxis is created from Ivory of an Elephant's tusk, which shows that the Umayyad caliphate, centered in Al-Andalus, spread to the Middle East and Northern Africa, where this elephant tusk was sourced from. Being that it was created in 968 CE, we know that this was after the death of Caliph 'Abd al-Rahman III who was the first Umayyad Caliph of Cordoba, because prior to him the leader of the Umayyads was the Emir, and prior to that was the Umayyad Caliph of Damascus.

The Pyxis is carved in deep relief, creating a high contrast between the subjects and the background. This is a secular piece, so it is non-aniconic, including depictions of humans and animals. The four main scenes in this piece show interesting themes about the Umayyads. The four main scenes are inside eight-lobed medallions that look like flowers.

The first scene shows lions dominating bulls in a violent battle. The lions are thought to be symbolic of the Umayyad dynasty, victorious and powerful over their enemies. This shows the state of Islam civilization in Al-Andalus in the 10th century, powerful and victorious. Later in this paper we will examine a change in this dynamic.

The second scene shows men collecting eggs from the nests of falcons. Like the first scene, this is meant to show the power of the Umayyads. In this

time period, falcons were considered a symbol of legitimacy, so picking eggs from their nests shows that the Umayyads were the proper rulers over Al-Andalus.

The third scene shows an Umayyad Calif being attended to by two servants. This Calif is likely Al-Mughira's father, although it could potentially be Al-Mughira. This scene shows the lavish lifestyle enjoyed by the royalty of the Umayyads, which connects to the luxurious nature of the three sources in this paper.

The fourth scene shows men on horseback picking dates. The date trees depicted are native to the lands of the east, so this imagery is likely an homage to the lost lands of the east that were not under Umayyad control at the time but rather under Abbasid control. However the intention of the scene was likely twofold, as picking dates is a princely action, and all four scenes, while having deeper meanings, are all princely actions or actions of royal court life (with the lion and bull scene being a metaphorical reference to political dominance).

One last aspect of analysis for the Pyxis is that it has remnants of jade on it. Jade, as an expensive luxury stone, shows the wealth of the Umayyad Caliphate of Cordoba.

The second object of analysis is the Folio from a Qur’an manuscript. Analysis will be focused on both the folio and the larger Qur’an manuscript that the folio is from. The manuscript is one of the largest surviving parchment manuscripts from the Nasrid dynasty in Al-Andalus. Being 21 inches tall and made on parchment, the manuscript is “one of the most ambitious” manuscripts

produced in the period according to the Met. Visually, a few things stand out from the folio page.

First, the boxy script of the first line. This script is Kufic calligraphy, the same style of calligraphy that we find on the Pyxis of Al-Mughira. Kufic script for the sura heading returns to Umayyad tradition. The gold leaf for the sura heading and the Kufic calligraphy distinguish this manuscript from earlier Qur'an manuscripts.

One thing that it has in common with earlier Qur'an manuscripts is the use of parchment. Although paper had been invented and was being used in the Middle East during the 13th century, it was not yet the standard in Al-Andalus, so the use of parchment is considered conservative. The script that the text is written in is Maghribi, and the lines are squared. The Maghribi script is less angular than the Kufic script of the heading and is instead rounded and more organic.

In addition to the writing, the page is ornately decorated by three colorful medallions. The larger of the three medallions is full of organic shapes which contrasts the angular Kufic script it is next to. These organic shapes are reminiscent of the organic designs that fill the space between scenes on the Pyxis of Al-Mughira. The smaller two medallions are within the body of the text and serve as verse markers, they are filled with angular geometric designs. Keep

these geometric designs in mind as we will soon explore geometric designers in the Palace of Lions.

Another aspect of the folio is the colored dots within the body of the texts. These colored dots are meant to indicate vowel signs. This method of dots was devised by Abu'l Aswas Duvalier of Basra (d. 688 CE), the father of Arabic grammar (Khan). This folio page combines traditions of Qur'an manuscripts while differentiating itself from others of its time by its size and medium.

One last thing I would like to discuss is the method of decoration of this piece. The Qur'an is a religious piece, and because of this it is aniconic. So, the decorations are geometric and colorful rather than including images of people or animals. This is in contrast to secular pieces like the Pyxis of Al-Mughira.

The third source for analysis is the Palace of Lions in the Alhambra. The Nasrid dynasty moved its capital to Granada because it was farther from the Christian powers of Castile and was close to the sea for a quick escape if necessary. On the mountains overlooking Grenada, the Alhambra was first built as a fortress for defense against Christian invasion.

The fact that the Alhambra was created as a fortress goes to show the political instability of the Nasrids in Al-Andalus. The Emirate of Granada was the last Islamic state in Al-Andalus as the reconquista continued to push Muslims out of Al-Andalus. Despite Castile being the clear adversary for the Nasrid empire, the Christian empire had influence on the architecture and art of the Islamic royalty. This can be seen in the Palace of the Lions, which holds similarities in layout to the Alcazar of Seville.

Water divides the court of lions into four quadrants, symbolizing the four rivers of paradise, wine, water, honey, and milk from the story shared by Abrahamic religions of the land of paradise. The outer section of the courtyard has arches and columns supporting a portico in a unique square on rectangle shape with two porticos on opposing sides across the length of the courtyard. The columns are either alone, or in groups of two or three, which creates a sense of unique design that still appears visually balanced. The arcades in the porticos and pavilions include arabesque stucco decoration that is extremely ornamented, with deep relief patterned sculpture reminiscent of the Pyxis of Al-Mughira.

The Palace of Lions is similar to the Pyxis of Al-Mughira in the centrality of animal sculpture to it's decoration. The twelve lions that stand at the base of the central fountain in the courtyard are carved in the round and have water spouting from their mouths. This center fountain is my favorite Islamic art piece as I think it so peacefully exemplifies the political state of the empire.

Water is central to life, and as such this fountain can be seen as the foundational life source of the empire. The lions stand surrounding the basin of water, protecting it. When coupled with the symbolic definition of the lion found in the medallion scene from the Pyxis of Al-Mughira, we can see this central fountain as showing the Nasrid Empire protecting Islamic livelihood in Al-Andalus. Although, these lions are not on the prowl, and they are not standing on offense.

Contrasting the scene of the lions and bulls, these lions are on defense, which I believe is perfect symbolism to the new capital of Grenada and the Alhambra, sitting on defense against the reconquista. For that reason, the central fountain is my favorite art piece.

In summary, Al-Andalus was controlled powerfully by the Umayyad Caliphate in the 10th century as reflected by the Pyxis of Al-Mughira, but as the Christian powers in the reconquista began to push Muslims out, Al-Andalus decreased as the center of the Islamic world. While on the decline in power, there were still beautiful works produced, as seen in the Folio page from a Qur'an

manuscript. Standing on its last limb, Islamic Al-Andalus through the Nasrid dynasty produced the Alhambra and subsequently the Palace of Lions, which symbolically depicted the constrained nature of Islamic Al-Andalus, while pulling from artistic tradition.

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